operations rooms are full of quotes by Sun Tzu and Kautilya, advocating surprise and deception and how to win wars without actually fighting one, but sadly there is none of that to be seen when it comes to actual plans, which are routine, obvious and unlikely to prevail in the face of actual combat.

After about six weeks in the chair, and having taken stock, I felt I should brief the PM on the way ahead and plans for the future. Modernization, of course, is always at the top of the agenda, but along with modernization, I felt that we should transition from a manpower-intensive to a technologically oriented Army. We already had a Short Service Commission (SSC) Scheme in the Army for entry at the officer level. I felt that a similar scheme, a Short Service Enrolment (SSE) Scheme could be introduced at the soldier level to be known as Tour of Duty. Jawans enrolled under this scheme would serve for three to four years with a reduced training period. On release, they would be absorbed by the industry or other services that would benefit from trained and disciplined manpower. A certain percentage who had done well could be retained for yet another 'Tour'. When I explained the broad contours of this to the PM, he appeared interested and asked me what numbers I was looking at. I had replied that initially, we could look at about 10 per cent of any given year's enrolment, which would translate to about 6000 to 7000 SSE recruits each year. It could start as a pilot project and based on the acceptability of the scheme, the numbers could be increased year on year, to a maximum of about 50 per cent. This was exclusively for the Army and was an idea that had occurred to me in late 2019/early 2020 based on my interactions with students and industry doyens.[6] Shri Anand Mahindra of Mahindra and Mahindra was particularly supportive of the scheme.[7] This was the start of what was finally to become the Agnipath Scheme.

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